LIBO

THE 12-MONTH BLUEPRINT

69 → 77 KG. NO SHORTCUTS.

Noah F. · Founder, Libo

Free. Share it. · v1 · November 2026

WHY 12 MONTHS

YOUR REAL POTENTIAL, NOT YOUR FASTEST RESULT

Most transformations you see online are eight weeks long. And most of them are gone eight weeks later.

I see it in the gym all the time. People with a supplement shelf, a new plan every Monday, a protein drink after every session, and they feel like they're doing everything right. Then life gets busy, they're out for two or three months, the eating stays the same and the training doesn't. That's not a character flaw. It's what happens when the whole thing was built for speed instead of for the long run.

This blueprint is the opposite. One year. Real food first. Training you can actually keep doing. It's not a science paper and it's not a sales funnel. It's what worked for me, written down honestly, with the parts I got wrong corrected.

7 yrs
stuck at 69 kg

12 mo
to about 77 kg

5
eggs a day

What "real potential" means here
Not the most you can gain in a summer. The body you can build **and keep**, because the habits that built it are still there in year two.

MY STORY, SHORT

I played football from 12, in the top youth league, with Bundesliga clubs watching. At 17 I weighed 69 kg at 1.81 m. At 20, 69 kg. At 24, still 69 kg. I spent two and a half years in Australia and never once signed up for a gym.

At the end of 2023, in Portugal, something clicked. I started training five, six times a week, wrote my own plans in my notes app and kept changing weights and variations. I never felt forced. Twelve months later I was around 77 kg, with more strength than I'd ever had.

The difference wasn't a secret product. It was a breakfast I didn't skip, a plan I didn't quit, and a year I didn't rush.

My rule: always be in movement. I do rest. But I'm never just sitting there. Don't be the robot who walks to a machine, sits down and stares at his phone until the next set. Between sets I walk around, swing my arms, stretch a bit. On rest days I still go for a walk. Even if you move slowly, keep moving. That's how your body stays loose and athletic.

THE YEAR AT A GLANCE

FOUR PHASES, THREE MONTHS EACH

Phase	Training	Food	Checkpoint
1 · Foundation months 1–3	3× full body, learn the lifts, warm-up circuit every time	Add the daily porridge. Hit your protein number.	Training 3× a week feels normal
2 · Build months 4–6	4× upper/lower, add weight or reps each week	Switch to the shake if porridge gets boring.	You can see and feel the difference
3 · Push months 7–9	5–6× my split: legs front/back and biceps/triceps on separate days	Same base, more variety: berries, mango, extra protein.	Lifts clearly heavier than month 1
4 · Own it months 10–12	Keep the split, test your lifts in the last weeks	Eat like this is normal, because by now it is.	Old photos vs now, plan year two

The only three rules that matter all year

1. Show up on your training days, even for a short session.
2. Hit your protein number most days (see Your numbers).
3. Do a little more than last time: one more rep or a bit more weight.

HOW MUCH TRAINING IS ENOUGH

I trained two to three hours a day back then: strength, then cardio, mobility and coordination on top. I was there that long because I liked it, not because I thought I had to be, and **you don't need that**. Muscle grows from hard sets done consistently, not from hours spent in the building. 45–75 minutes of focused work is plenty.

If you already train a sport every day (football like I did, for example), add 2–3 strength sessions of about 40 minutes and you'll grow fast.

NEW TO THE GYM? BUILD UP TO IT (MONTHS 1-6)

Six days is a lot if you've never trained. The first six months build the base:

- **Months 1–3 · Full body, 3× a week:** squat, push-up or bench press, pulldown, Romanian deadlift, plank. 2–3 sets × 10–15 reps.
- **Months 4–6 · Upper/lower, 4× a week:** upper: bench press, row, overhead press, pulldown, curls + pushdowns. Lower: squat, Romanian deadlift, lunge, leg curl, calf raise. 3 sets × 10–15 reps.
- **Months 7–12 · My split** (next page). Every 6–8 weeks, do an **easy week** with half the sets so your joints and head can recover.

After the weights

I added cardio, mobility and coordination work after strength. You don't need all of it: 2 short cardio sessions a week (20–30 min walking, cycling or a football kickabout) and a few minutes of stretching after each session keep you athletic, not just bigger.

TRAINING

HOW I ACTUALLY TRAINED

Before every session: warm-up + stretch circuit (8–10 min)
3–4 minutes of easy cardio (bike, rower or skipping rope), then 1–2 rounds of: arm circles · band pull-aparts · cat–cow · world's greatest stretch · leg swings forwards and sideways · hip circles · 10 bodyweight squats. Then 1–2 light sets of your first exercise. Keep the stretches short and moving; save long holds (30 s+) for after the session.

How I did my sets: 8–10 clean reps on the big presses and squats, 12–15 on isolation exercises, 15–20 on calves, every rep controlled, stopping 1–2 reps before failure. About once a week I did a **heavy session**: 4–6 reps on the main lift of the day. When you hit the top of your rep range on every set, go heavier next time. That's progressive overload, and it's the whole game. Between sets, rest about 1–3 minutes (longer for heavy lifts), but stay on your feet: walk, swing your arms, and **stretch the muscle you're training for 10–20 seconds**: chest on chest day, back and shoulders on back or shoulder day. For me it feels like I can press more and use the muscle better. Short stretches like this don't cost you strength (only long holds of a minute or more can), and you get your mobility done without adding a single minute to your session.

MY SPLIT (MONTHS 7-12)

5–6 days a week. The idea: the front and back of the legs on different days, biceps and triceps on different days, so every muscle gets my full energy.

Day	Focus	Example exercises
Mon	Chest + triceps	Incline dumbbell press, machine chest press, dips, rope pushdown
Tue	Legs FRONT + calves	Hack squat, leg press, leg extension, calf raises
Wed	Back + biceps	Wide lat pulldown, T-bar row, chest-supported row, curls
Thu	Shoulders + core	Arnold press, lateral raises, rear-delt fly, face pulls, leg raises
Fri	Legs BACK	Romanian deadlift, hip thrust, leg curl, back extension
Sat	Arms / weak spots	Optional: 3–4 exercises for whatever is lagging
Sun	Rest (still moving)	A long walk, stretching, eating well

The exercises are examples. Swap any of them for a variation you like; I kept changing mine every few weeks.

Feel the muscle, not the exercise
Which exact exercise you pick matters less than you think. What matters is that you hit the target muscle and **feel it working**.

- **First weeks:** you'll be sore after almost every session, and your arms will feel small. Normal, you're untrained.
- **After 1–2 months:** the soreness fades as your body adapts, and you don't need it to grow. But during every set you should clearly feel the muscle you're training, burning and tired by the last reps.
- **Still don't feel it?** Then something in the movement is off. Watch a video (Libo has one for almost every exercise), ask a trainer in your gym, or swap to another exercise for the same muscle.

Sharp pain in a joint is not "feeling it". Stop and get your form checked.

NUTRITION

REAL FOOD FIRST

I didn't count calories. I love food: variety, cooking, food that looks good. I'm not a fan of eating out of tubs, especially stuff I haven't researched. What I did was simple: **keep eating what you already eat, and add one big breakfast every day.** If you live with your parents, it's even easier: keep the family dinners and add the breakfast.

YOUR NUMBERS

Find your weight. Protein is the number that matters most; the calories are a starting point. If nothing changes in the mirror for a month or two, add about 200 kcal.

Weight	Protein / day	Per meal (×4)	Water	Maintenance kcal	Build kcal
60 kg	96–132 g	24–33 g	2.1 L	2,511	2,811–3,011
65 kg	104–143 g	26–36 g	2.3 L	2,589	2,889–3,089
70 kg	112–154 g	28–39 g	2.5 L	2,666	2,966–3,166
75 kg	120–165 g	30–41 g	2.6 L	2,744	3,044–3,244
80 kg	128–176 g	32–44 g	2.8 L	2,821	3,121–3,321
85 kg	136–187 g	34–47 g	3.0 L	2,899	3,199–3,399
90 kg	144–198 g	36–50 g	3.2 L	2,976	3,276–3,476
95 kg	152–209 g	38–52 g	3.3 L	3,054	3,354–3,554
100 kg	160–220 g	40–55 g	3.5 L	3,131	3,431–3,631

Protein 1.6–2.2 g per kg (Morton et al., 2018). Water ≈ 35 ml per kg, more when it's hot or you train hard. Calories: Mifflin–St Jeor for a man of 180 cm, age 22, training 3–5× a week (×1.6), so add or subtract about 60 kcal per 10 cm of height. Build = maintenance + 300 to 500 kcal. All values are estimates.

MY PORRIDGE (MONTHS 1-2, WINTER)

- 150 g oats
- 150 ml almond or oat milk (start with less, add more as needed)
- 4–5 dried dates, pitted
- 1 teaspoon good honey
- 1 big ripe banana (or 2 small ones; the riper, the sweeter)
- 1 teaspoon peanut butter

Bring everything to a boil, then let it simmer gently for about 5 minutes until it's a thick porridge. Every day, at least 5–6 times a week.

MY SHAKE (FROM MONTH 2, WHEN PORRIDGE GOT BORING)

Same thing, cold, in a blender: 150 g oats, 200–250 ml almond or oat milk, banana, dates, honey, peanut butter and a spoon of chia seeds. Add milk until it's as thick as you like.

Recipe	kcal	Protein	Carbs	Fat
Porridge, almond milk	857	**25 g**	143 g	17 g
Porridge, oat milk	907	**26 g**	153 g	17 g
Shake, oat milk + chia	1,001	**29 g**	160 g	22 g

Honest correction: it's a calorie engine, not a protein bomb
I used to call this porridge high in protein. It's around 907 kcal but only about 26 g of protein. For someone stuck at 69 kg for years, that extra energy every morning is probably exactly what finally made the scale move. To make it a real protein meal:

- Use cow's milk or soy milk instead of almond milk (shake with 300 ml milk: 36 g protein).
- Stir 250 g quark or skyr in after cooking, or eat it on the side (porridge + quark: **55 g protein**).
- Or add a scoop of whey, if it's a product you've actually researched (see Supplements).

Swap things in whenever you're bored: dried berries, mango, a bit more peanut butter. Look up the values online for anything new; that's all I ever did.

A REAL DAY

WHAT I ACTUALLY ATE, ESTIMATED

Meal	kcal	Protein	Carbs	Fat
Breakfast: small roll, avocado, 2 eggs, mayo, bacon	474	**23 g**	28 g	29 g
Straight after: the porridge (oat milk)	907	**26 g**	153 g	17 g
At the gym: 3 boiled eggs	215	**19 g**	1 g	14 g
Snack: a roast chicken thigh from the supermarket	345	**36 g**	0 g	23 g
Lunch: peanut-coconut chicken with rice	1,004	**52 g**	113 g	36 g
Dinner: red lentil pot with chicken	769	**74 g**	82 g	11 g
Total	3,714	**230 g**	376 g	130 g

Lunch and dinner were one plate each from the rotation below (this day: peanut-coconut rice, then the lentil pot). Sometimes I had a second plate, sometimes not. Five eggs a day in total. Water: 2–3 litres.

That's about 230 g of protein, roughly 3.3 g per kg at my starting 69 kg: more than the target, from completely normal food. And 3,714 kcal sounds like a lot, but training 2–3 hours a day burns a lot too, which is why it only added up to about 0.7 kg a month. Nothing special. Just every day.

MY LUNCH AND DINNER ROTATION

Always the same base: 120–150 g rice or pasta (dry weight) and 150 g chicken breast, then whatever I felt like that day.

Plate	kcal	Protein	Carbs	Fat
Peanut-coconut chicken with rice (peanut butter + coconut milk sauce)	1,004	**52 g**	113 g	36 g
Fried rice: stir-fried with vegetables and chicken	763	**46 g**	109 g	14 g
Red lentil pot: 150 g red lentils, vegetables, chicken cooked in	769	**74 g**	82 g	11 g
Same lentil pot with smoked tofu instead of chicken	844	**65 g**	84 g	23 g
Pasta with green pesto and pan-fried chicken	951	**54 g**	98 g	35 g
Rice, vegetables, half chicken and half tofu	771	**39 g**	110 g	18 g
Salmon with rice and vegetables	866	**42 g**	109 g	26 g

Calculated with 135 g dry rice or pasta and 150 g raw chicken breast. The sauce uses 20 g peanut butter and about 100 ml coconut milk; pesto 50 g (about a quarter of a jar). Swap chicken for smoked tofu, fish or lean meat whenever you like.

Swaps I used a lot: half chicken and half tofu, or half beef and half tofu. Salmon often instead of chicken or beef. I don't really eat pork.

QUICK PLATES (WHEN THERE'S NO TIME)

Same rice or pasta portion, then one can of tuna **in its own juice, never in oil**, some seasoning, mix, done. One can (about 150 g drained) is about **39 g protein** for 174 kcal.

Plate	kcal	Protein	Carbs	Fat
Pasta + 1 can of tuna	653	**56 g**	95 g	4 g
Rice + 1 can of tuna	647	**48 g**	104 g	2 g

Tuna contains a little mercury, so keep it to a few times a week. Salmon is the better everyday fish.

MY SNACKS (ONE A DAY, ROTATING)

Snack	kcal	Protein	Carbs	Fat
Roast chicken thigh from the supermarket	345	**36 g**	0 g	23 g
2 bananas and a coffee	210	**3 g**	47 g	1 g
The morning shake again, lighter (75 g oats)	722	**19 g**	116 g	17 g
Croissant + peanut butter, warmed in the air fryer	332	**9 g**	30 g	20 g
The treat: croissant + a bit of Nutella + a bit of peanut butter, air fryer	345	**8 g**	34 g	20 g
Croissant + half an avocado + a banana	461	**8 g**	52 g	23 g

The air-fryer croissant is crazy good, especially the Nutella + peanut butter one, so be careful with it: sometimes, not every day. Nutella breaks out my skin, so most of the time I go peanut butter only. Only the chicken is a real protein snack; on the other days the eggs do that job.

Evening cravings

When I really wanted something sweet in the evening, I mostly ate fruit, especially mango. Go to the fruit market and buy whatever looks good: it's cheaper than chocolate from the supermarket and better for you. A whole big mango is about 180 kcal; a 100 g bar of chocolate is 535.

And honestly, sometimes we all want chocolate. That's what the croissant is for, and sometimes it's fine to just buy the chocolate or the ice cream. Just don't do what I did once: 400 g of ice cream in one night (840 kcal). My stomach hurt for two days. Not recommended.

A note on red lentils

Cheap, full of protein and fibre, and one of my favourite pots. But too much gave me stomach aches and a lot of air in my belly. 150 g dry was my limit: that cooks up to about 375 g, because lentils grow to about two and a half times their dry weight. If they don't agree with you, use less or go for rice with chicken, fish, eggs or tofu instead.

SUPPLEMENTS, HONESTLY

REAL FOOD FIRST. IF YOU USE THEM, USE GOOD ONES.

I'm not against supplements. Some are genuinely useful. But I'd want you to spend weeks, not a few hours, reading about anything before you take it every day for months. And buy only products that are independently tested (look for the **Kölner Liste** or **Informed Sport** labels).

Creatine monohydrate
I took it for the first three months and liked how it felt. Then I stopped about a year ago and kept everything. The facts:

- **3–5 g a day**, every day. I took 5 g. No loading phase needed.
- It takes about **3–4 weeks** to fill your muscles, and about 4–6 weeks to wash out after you stop.
- **Timing barely matters**: morning, after training or evening all work. Taking it daily is what counts.
- It doesn't dissolve well in cold water, so put it in the shake or porridge.
- Expect **1–2 kg of extra water weight** in the first weeks. That's normal, not fat.

Protein powder (whey or plant)
It's just protein, food in powder form. I've tried whey a few times but never used it consistently, and I still haven't found my favourite. The last one I tried from my gym was full of sugar, and the ones without sugar are full of sweeteners. Those are approved and considered safe, I just don't want them in my shake. Powder is a convenience, not a shortcut: handy on busy days, never a replacement for real meals.

- **Read the label:** a short ingredient list, no added sugar, ideally unflavoured. Use the banana and dates in your shake for sweetness.
- **Pea protein** is a good plant option. In studies it built about as much muscle as whey. It's a bit lower in some amino acids, so use a slightly bigger scoop or a pea + rice blend.
- **If whey upsets your stomach** (lactose), try a whey isolate or a plant protein. That's usually what people mean when they say their body works better with plant protein.

BCAAs
As footballers we were given them. But if you hit your daily protein (see Your numbers), they add nothing extra: whole protein already contains them.

TRACKING

TRACK WHAT HELPS YOU, NOT WHAT STRESSES YOU

Honestly, I didn't track much. I weighed myself maybe once a month at the start, and the last time was about three months ago. I didn't take photos on a fixed date either, just when I felt like it. Weighing yourself every day or every week can turn into stress or obsession, and that's not the point.

- **My target was visual:** more muscle, more strength, staying healthy and athletic. Not a number on the scale.
- **My real measure:** leaving every session completely exhausted, knowing I gave my maximum. And getting real, whole food in every day, in all the ways I described.
- **Lifts:** this is what I really tracked: how the weight on each exercise went up. I wrote it in my notes app, but honestly it got very confusing. Today I'd use an app: in Libo you log every set, and it shows what you lifted last time right next to it, so you know exactly what to beat.

If you like numbers (optional)
Weigh yourself once a month, same day, in the morning before eating. In year 1, roughly 0.5–1 kg a month is a healthy pace; much faster is mostly fat. If the mirror and the scale don't move for a month or two, eat about 200 kcal more. Photos whenever you want, same light, front and side.

WHAT I BELIEVED VS WHAT'S TRUE

I GOT SOME THINGS WRONG. HERE'S THE HONEST VERSION.

I SAID
My porridge is full of protein.

TRUTH
About 26 g of 907 kcal. It's a calorie engine. Add quark or milk to make it a protein meal.

I SAID
I gained 8 kg of muscle.

TRUTH
Close. My body fat was under 10 % before and was still under 10 % on my gym's scale last year (those scales can be off by a few %, but the mirror agrees), and I was never fat. So at most about 2 kg of the 8 kg can be fat: **6 kg or more is lean mass**. And I stopped creatine a year ago and kept it, so it isn't water either. "Lean mass" also counts the water and carbs stored in muscle, so call it mostly muscle, not exactly 8 kg. About 1 % of body weight a month: a strong first year, not a miracle.

I SAID
What you gain fast, you lose fast.

TRUTH
Muscle you've built comes back faster after a break ("muscle memory"). What fades is the habit, and fast bulks are mostly fat. That's why this is 12 months.

I SAID
Creatine in the evening isn't good.

TRUTH
Timing barely matters. Taking it every day does.

I SAID
BCAAs would help my recovery.

TRUTH
Not if you hit your protein. Whole protein already contains them.

I SAID
High reps make the muscle fibres more compact and longer-lasting.

TRUTH
Muscle grows about the same anywhere from roughly 6 to 30 reps, as long as you go close to failure. High reps are great for clean technique and your joints, not for "denser" muscle.

I SAID
Heavy sessions break the fibres, and that's what gives strength.

TRUTH
Damage isn't what builds muscle. Heavy sets make you stronger mainly because your nervous system learns to use more of the muscle at once. That's why mixing both works.

WHERE 12 MONTHS GETS YOU

THE RESULT, HONESTLY

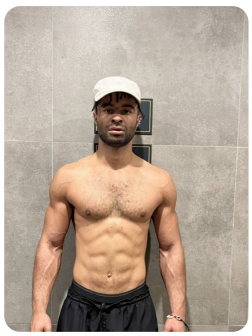


2023 69 KG



MAY 2024
8 months in

Real photos, no filters. 2023 is the last year at 69 kg. The one on the right is May 2024, about eight months after I started.



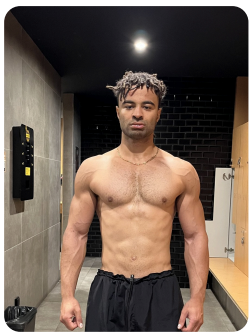
JAN 2024
4 MONTHS IN



MAR
6 MONTHS IN



APR
7 MONTHS IN



MAY
8 MONTHS IN



JUL
10 MONTHS IN

Month by month: the photos I took along the way, whenever I felt like it.

Why 6 kg looks like way more than 6 kg

- **It's the minimum.** If my body fat stayed about the same, it's closer to 7 kg of lean mass.
- **It's near the top for a natural first year.** A common coaching rule of thumb (Lyle McDonald) says about 9–11 kg of muscle is possible in year 1 if everything is perfect. Most people get half of that or less.
- **Every kilo shows when you're lean.** I started with about 62 kg of lean mass, so 6–7 kg more is roughly 10 % more muscle, right where people look: shoulders, chest, arms, back.
- **Why others look the same after a year:** same weights every week, a dirty bulk that hides everything, or three good weeks and then two off.

MY NUMBERS

Exercise	Sets × reps	Weight
Hack squat	4 × 8	120–140 kg
Leg press	3 × 12	120 kg
Lat pulldown, wide grip	3 × 10	90 kg
Machine chest press	3 × 10	90–100 kg
Smith machine incline press	4 × 8	80–100 kg
T-bar row	3 × 10	40–75 kg
Barbell curl	3 × 12	30–35 kg
Rope pushdown	3 × 12	35 kg
Dips	3 × 10–12	bodyweight + 6 kg

Working sets, not targets. Machines differ from gym to gym, so only ever compare yourself with yourself.

START TODAY

DAY 1 OF 365

You don’t need a perfect plan. You need to start this week and still be going in month 12. Weigh yourself tomorrow morning, buy oats, bananas and dates, and book three training days in your calendar.

Want the training part done for you? Libo is the brand and the train-and-earn platform I built for exactly this: 820+ exercises with video, guided workouts and programmes, and a system made to keep you consistent. Find Libo on the App Store or at **liboworld.com**.

See you in month 12.
Noah F.

This is general guidance from my own experience, not medical or nutritional advice. If you have a medical condition, are under 18, or have a history of eating disorders, talk to a doctor before changing how you eat or train. Nutrition values are estimates based on typical label values.

Sources: Morton RW et al. (2018) protein supplementation and resistance training, Br J Sports Med 52:376–384 · Jäger R et al. (2017) ISSN position stand: protein and exercise, JISSN 14:20 · Kreider RB et al. (2017) ISSN position stand: creatine, JISSN 14:18 · Wolfe RR (2017) BCAAs and muscle protein synthesis: myth or reality?, JISSN 14:30 · Schoenfeld BJ et al. (2017) weekly set volume and hypertrophy, J Sports Sci 35:1073–1082 · Schoenfeld BJ et al. (2017) strength and hypertrophy with low- vs high-load training, J Strength Cond Res 31:3508–3523 · Schoenfeld BJ et al. (2021) the rep-range continuum, Sports 9:32 · Damas F et al. (2016) muscle damage and hypertrophy, J Physiol 594:5209–5222 · Behm DG et al. (2016) acute effects of stretching, Appl Physiol Nutr Metab 41:1–11 · Schoenfeld BJ et al. (2018) mind-muscle connection and hypertrophy, Eur J Sport Sci 18:705–712 · Schoenfeld BJ, Contreras B (2013) is muscle soreness a valid indicator of adaptation?, Strength Cond J 35:16–21 · Schoenfeld BJ et al. (2016) longer rest periods and hypertrophy, J Strength Cond Res 30:1805–1812 · Babault N et al. (2015) pea vs whey protein and muscle thickness, JISSN 12:3 · Banaszek A et al. (2019) pea vs whey protein, Sports 7:12 · Seaborne RA et al. (2018) epigenetic memory of hypertrophy, Sci Rep 8:1898 · Iraki J et al. (2019) nutrition recommendations for bodybuilders, Sports 7:154 · Mifflin MD et al. (1990) Am J Clin Nutr 51:241–247 · EFSA (2010) dietary reference values for water.